IM ANGESICHT DES TODES

AUSSTELLUNGSARCHITEKTUR / RAUMINSTALLATION,
FRANKFURT, 2024



Im Angesicht des Todes (2024) Frankfurt

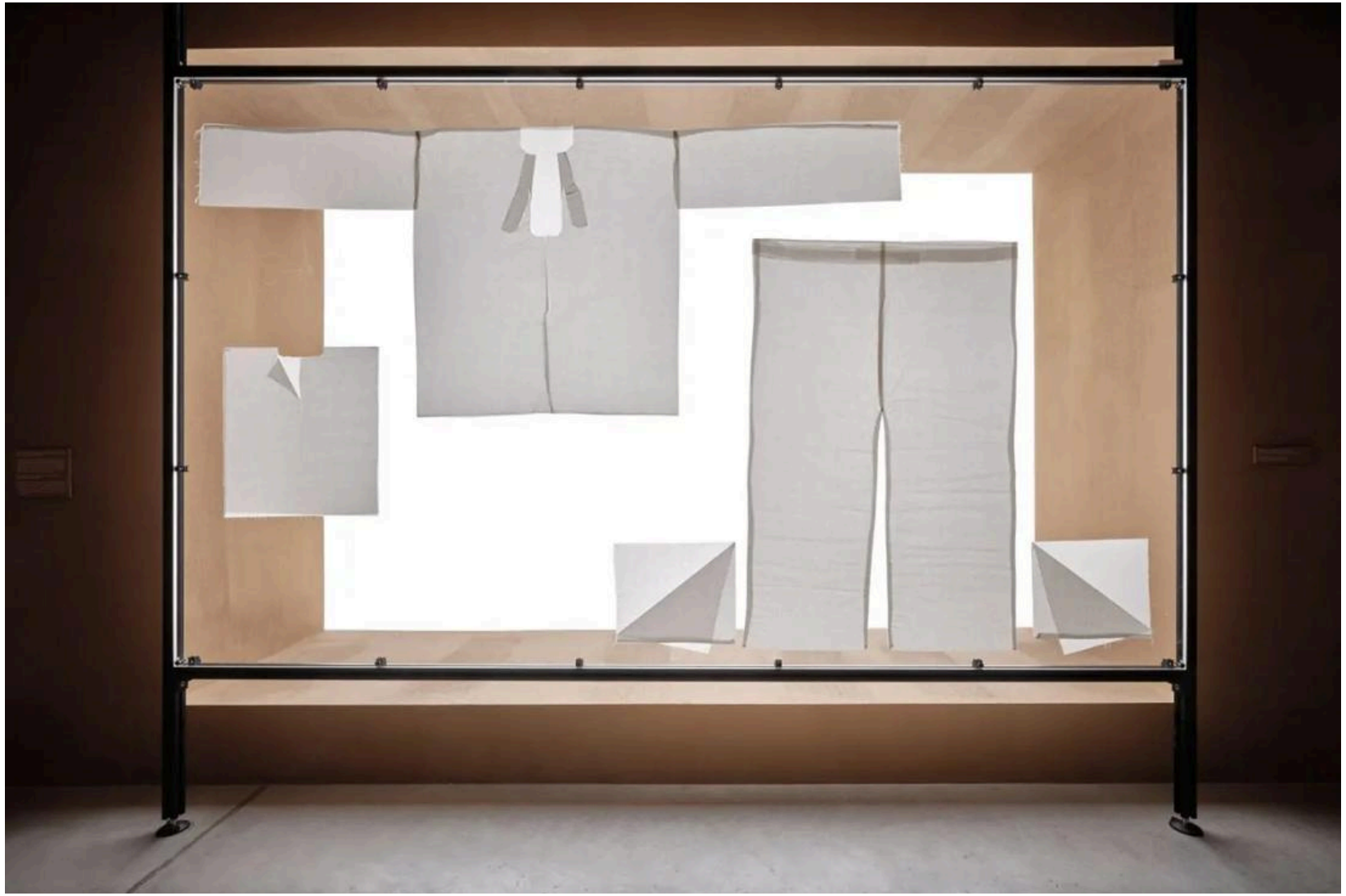
In 2024, YRD.Works realised the exhibition architecture for In the Face of Death — Dying in the Jewish Narrative Tradition at the Jewish Museum Frankfurt, a temporary exhibition of around 600 square metres that ran for about seven months. The collaboration with the museum had begun in 2023 with another exhibition project. From the start, this resulted in a brief to contribute, alongside the design solution, an independent artistic position that relates conceptually to the exhibition's theme and thus becomes part of its content.

The design work began with a decision against something. The obvious imagery of death — black as the colour of mourning, darkness, heaviness — was deliberately not taken up. Instead, the incomprehensible aspect of death came to the fore, translated into a bright, indefinable space of light. The infinity of this light was countered with clay as an earthly, organic material: transience, warmth and physical presence as a counter-register to the immaterial light. Clay also brought a reading of resource politics into the design, without explaining it.

The rooms are finished throughout in earth-brown clay paint on walls and ceilings, while the floor remains light exposed concrete. Narrow light edges integrated into the wall and ceiling junctions structure the sequence of rooms and form the only lighting. The furnishings follow a two-material principle: brown-glazed timber panels with milled bilingual lettering, small framed black-and-white prints, black steel-framed showcases with ritual garments of white linen hung inside, a cloth panel lit from above in front of a wall niche, a pale spruce-coloured wooden coffin on the floor, narrow black benches, a wall-mounted flat screen and black wall showcases with paper- and textile-based objects.

The architecture had to meet two requirements at once. It was to accommodate the diversity of the exhibits — art objects, unique pieces, everyday items, light-sensitive paper prints and interactive media stations — without dominating them, while remaining distinct enough to be legible as an intervention in its own right. The collective worked through this tension with a reduced, monochrome shell that allows diversity without commenting on it, placing the spatial and atmospheric register as a second level of reading alongside the intellectual one of the exhibits.

Over the course of the exhibition, the architecture added a sensory dimension to the largely text-based approach to the subject. It aimed less at grief than at a diffuse sense of what is incomprehensible about death — a spatial temperature in which death is experienced less as an image than as a condition of being present.



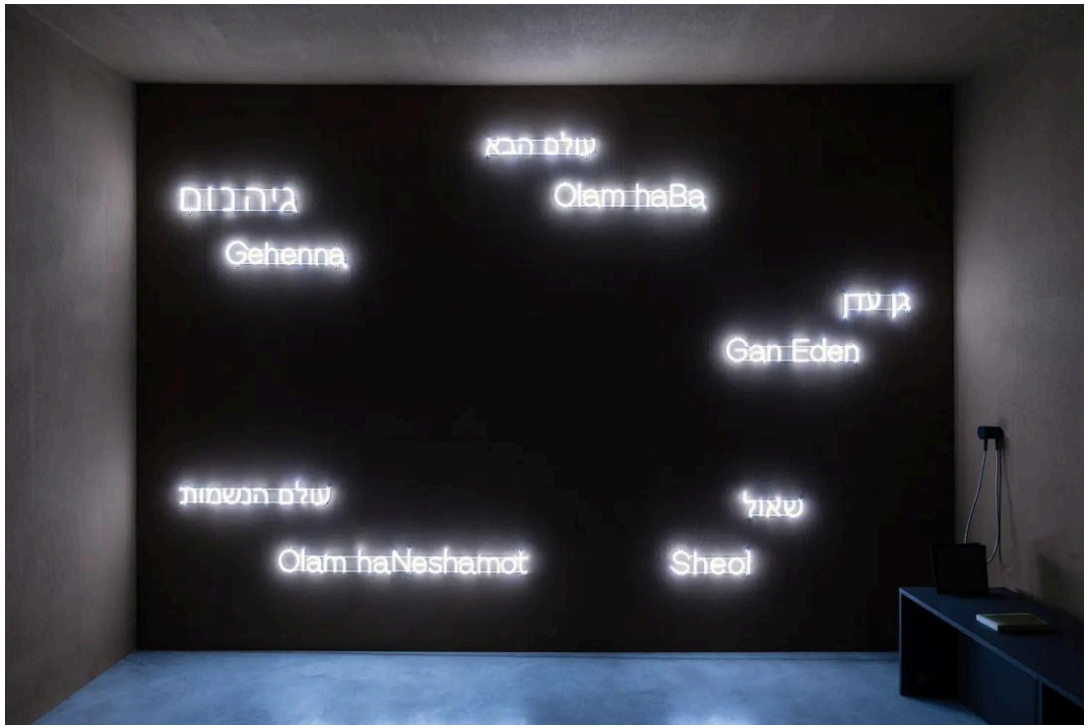
Im Angesicht des Todes (2024) Frankfurt

IM ANGESICHT DES TODES



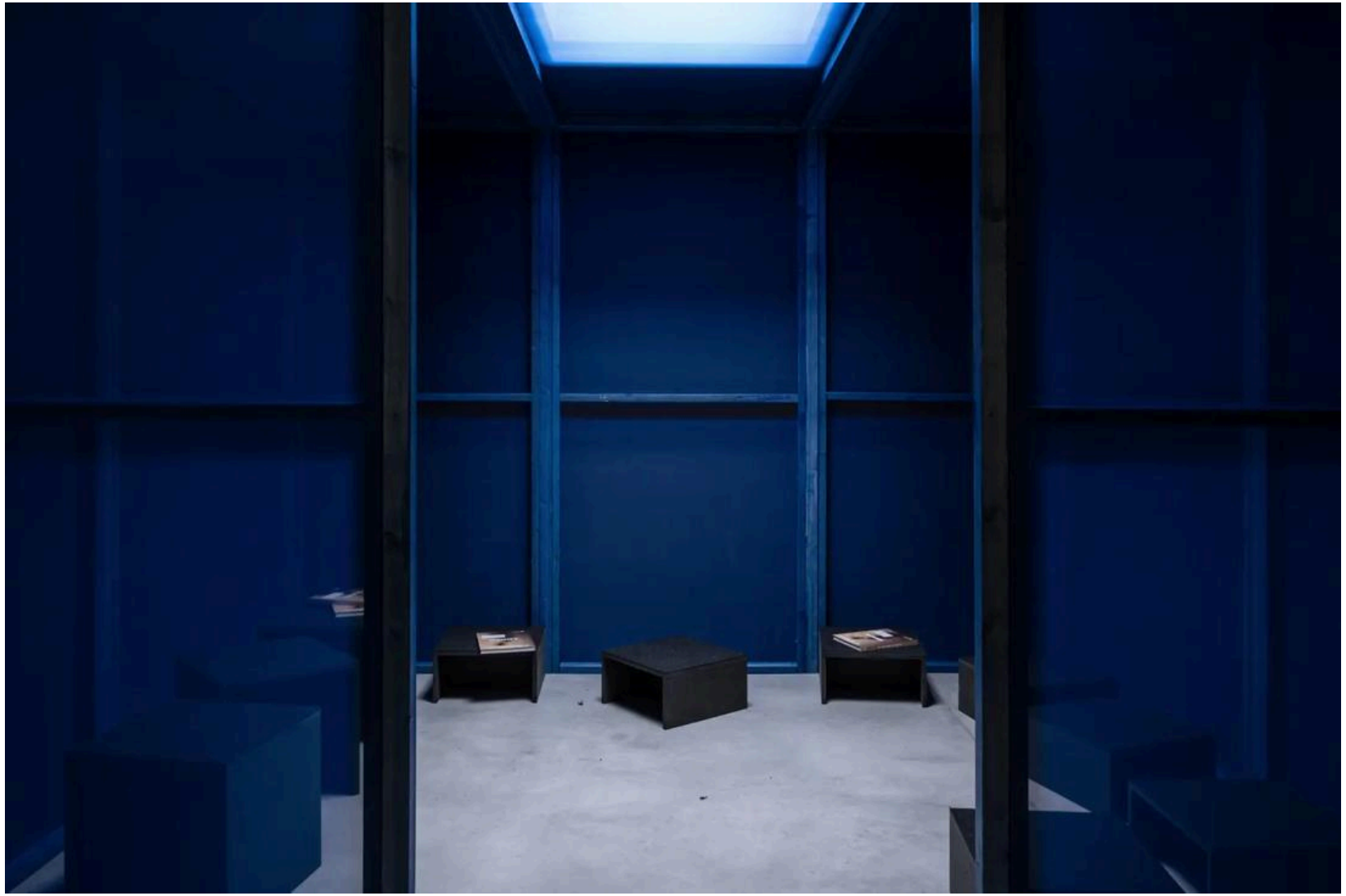
Im Angesicht des Todes (2024) Frankfurt





Im Angesicht des Todes (2024) Frankfurt

IM ANGESICHT DES TODES



Im Angesicht des Todes (2024) Frankfurt

IM ANGESICHT DES TODES